

READINGS IN PHILIPPINE HISTORY

John Lee P. Candelaria
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Introduction

Reforms to the basic education system of the Philippines have resulted into the introduction of the K to 12 program, a much needed development since the Philippines has been the last country in Asia with a 10-year pre-university cycle. Globally, the accepted span of basic education is 12 years, and it is recognized as the standard for students and professionals.

With the lengthening of basic education, there is a need for higher education institutions to respond with the same enthusiasm in reforming their respective course offerings and programs. The Commission on Higher Education (CHED) approved the New General Education (GE) Program, which aims to restructure the old GE program in higher education institutions to respond to the challenges of the times. It is geared toward the holistic development of the person in overlapping realms of the individual, the Filipino community, and the global community.

It is in these realities that the General Education course *Readings in Philippine History* is situated, with the course description “Philippine history viewed from the lens of selected primary sources in different periods, analysis, and interpretations.” The focus of the course is to develop historiographical skills connected to context and content analysis, applying both analytical strategies in themes and topics across the Philippine past. Primary sources will be the ultimate bridge between the past and the present, allowing spaces for students to simply not parrot facts about the past but to gain knowledge that can be used in proposing solutions to the problems of today.

The use of primary sources in studying about the past connects the history learner to the text producers themselves, allowing for a richer experience of understanding and appreciation. However, the use of primary sources for those who lack the sufficient training and knowledge could also be disastrous, and may be a source of misunderstanding and alienation to the events of the past. This book is crafted to provide a strategy on how to study Philippine history through primary sources, in hopes that the teacher and the student would have the best opportunity to learn and study about the past while taking great care in watching the steps they take in their attempt to utilize primary sources in history.

Organization of the Book

This book is divided into five chapters:

Chapter 1 – Introduction to History: Definition, Issues, Sources, and Methodology is a general appraisal of history as a discipline and as a narrative. This chapter aims to introduce the students to history as a theoretical field, as well as discuss the historiographical method of the evaluation of primary sources.

Chapter 2 – Content and Contextual Analysis of Selected Primary Sources in Philippine History talks about the two methods of analysis mentioned as it applies to historical research, using primary sources from across the periods of Philippine history as exemplars of analyses.

Chapter 3 – Philippine History: Spaces for Conflict and Controversies attempts to dissect the issues surrounding historical interpretation—how a single record of the past can be interpreted in multiple ways and the challenges it poses to the students of history.

Chapter 4 – Social, Political, Economic, and Cultural Issues in Philippine History is centered on the attempt to understand current issues and concerns using the lens of history, in recognition of the fact that the problems of society today could well be addressed by looking at the roots of the problems. This chapter discusses the mandatory topics on the Philippine Constitution, agrarian reform, and taxation.

Chapter 5 – Doing History: A Guide for Students is an attempt by the authors to guide the students in the historical research methods they will have to undergo in the process of completing the course. This chapter recognizes the realities of the present generation and aims to use these realities to the advantage of the students in the process of learning history by doing history.

Note to Teachers

For the teachers, remember that Philippine history is not set in stone; and only in continuous learning and updating historical knowledge can we make ourselves aware that the trends in knowledge of Philippine history is regularly changing. It is your responsibility to keep track of the discourse of the Philippine past and keep yourself knowledgeable to be able to provide your students with the best instruction and assistance in understanding our nation's narrative.

Note to Students

For the students, it is high time you do away with the misconception that history is a boring field of study. You may have been victims of the stereotypes appropriated to history as it has been taught in the classroom for centuries. Realize that by studying history, we situate ourselves in the story of the nation, a necessary endeavor to be able to know more about our identity and find out how we can help solve the problems of today and move forward to the future.